

# What is emotion in the first years of life?



T/Th 9:35-10:25am

Professor Casey Lew-Williams

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No precepts next week!

This is an intentional mini-break so that  
you can feel balance in your life.

# Emotions are a nearly constant part of our lives



SITUATION

EXPRESSION



PHYSIOLOGY



THOUGHTS



**WHAT IS AN  
EMOTION?**







Raise your hand if you felt an emotion  
in the last day

We share a lot of knowledge about emotions

sympathy

## **Pulse of the Nation: U.S. Mood Throughout the Day inferred from Twitter**

Less Happy  More Happy

<http://www.ccs.neu.edu/home/amislove/twittermood>

# Two competing theories

- **Basic Emotions Theory**

Emotions are innate, universal, and easily recognized by stereotyped facial expressions.

- **Theory of Constructed Emotion**

Emotions are our brain's interpretation of how we are feeling, based on its past experience and knowledge.

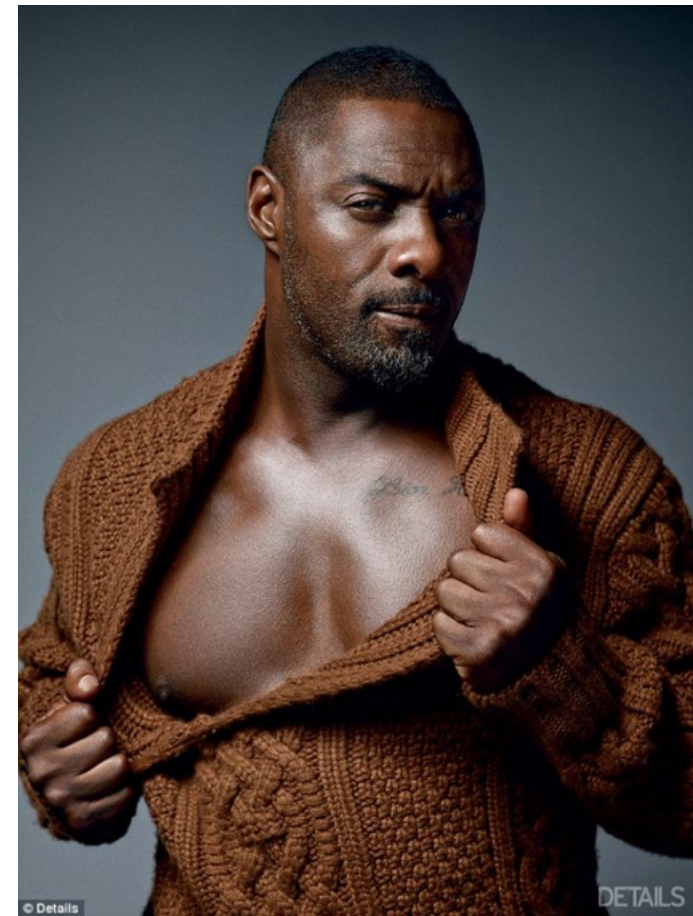
It is very easy to take you all  
on an emotional rollercoaster

















Kan man ha roligare??

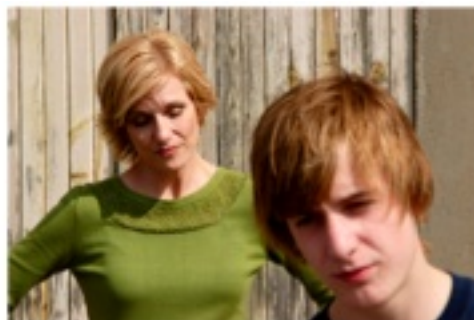
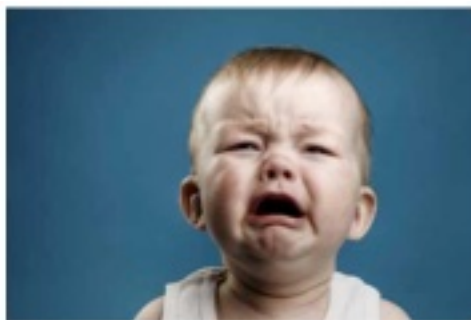
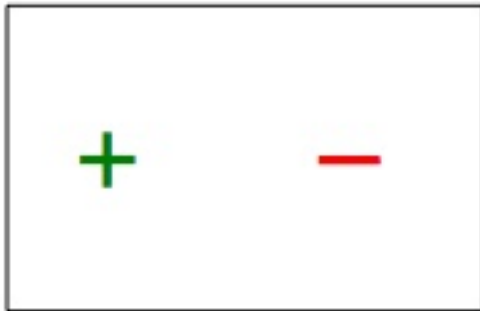


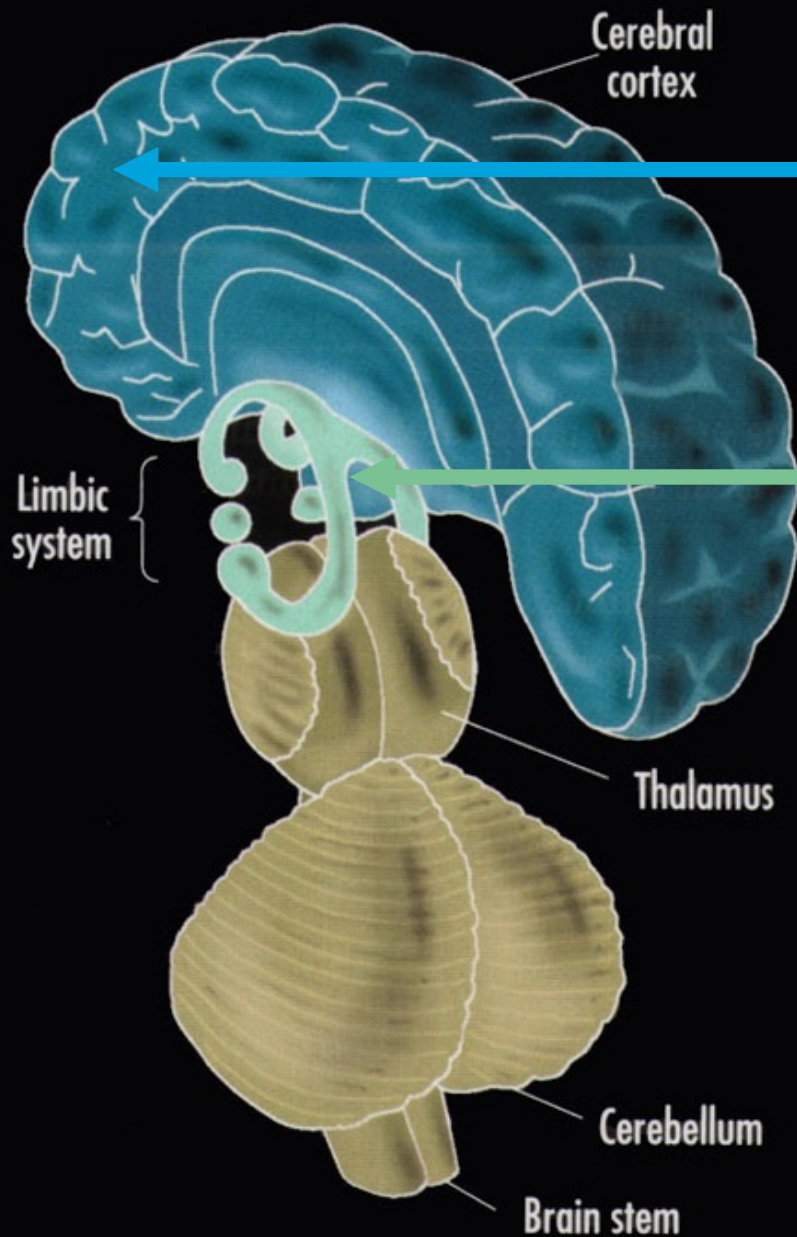






# What is emotion?





voluntary action, complex judgment, symbolic thought

emotion, motivation, simple judgment

'basic' emotions

disgust



'basic' emotions

fear





'basic' emotions

joy



'basic' emotions

sadness



# 'basic' emotions

## anger



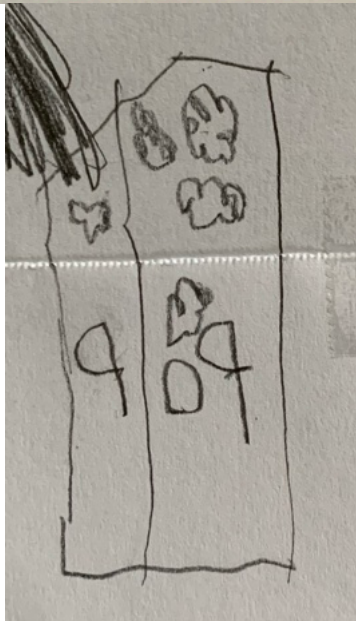
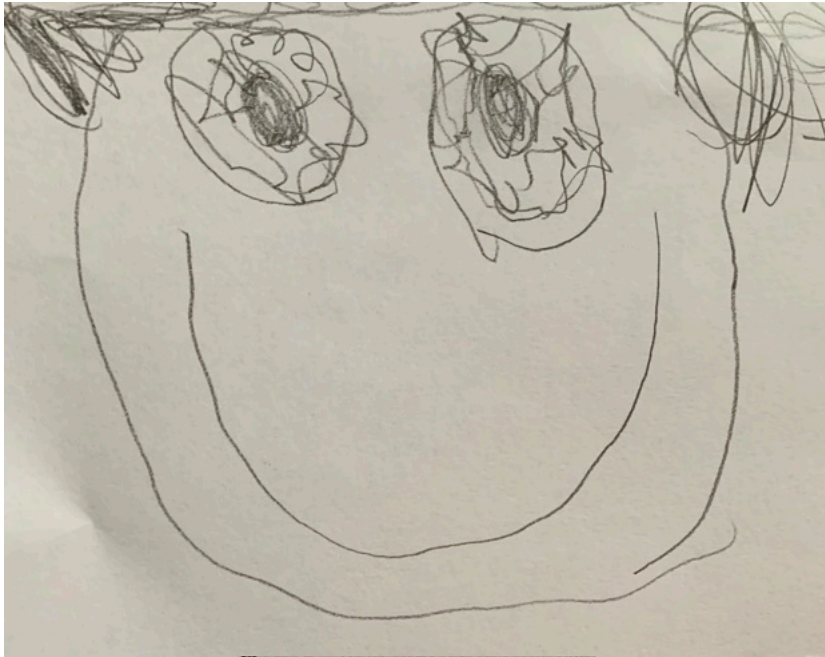
'basic' emotions

surprise

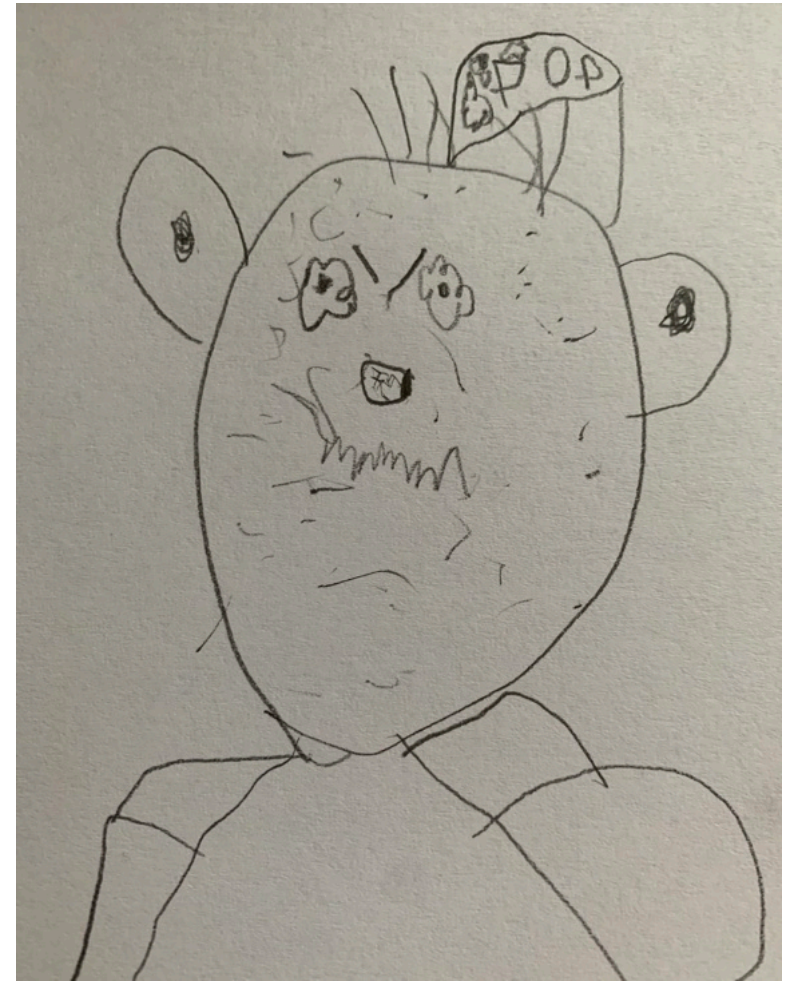




happy



hangry



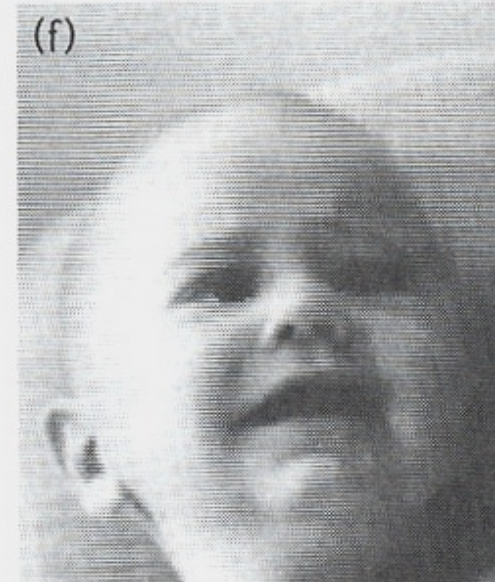
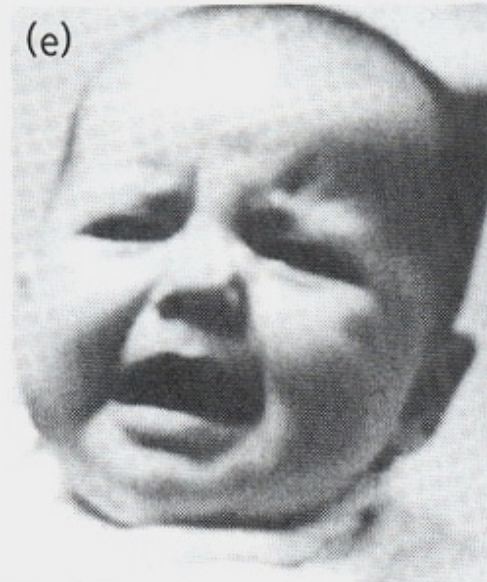


# Universality of emotional expression





# Universality of emotional expression



# Why emotions?





Expressing one's own emotions

(joy and fear)

We put a robotic lander on a moving comet!



# Expressing emotions: Joy

Reflexive smiling in newborns - - - - social smiles by 2 months

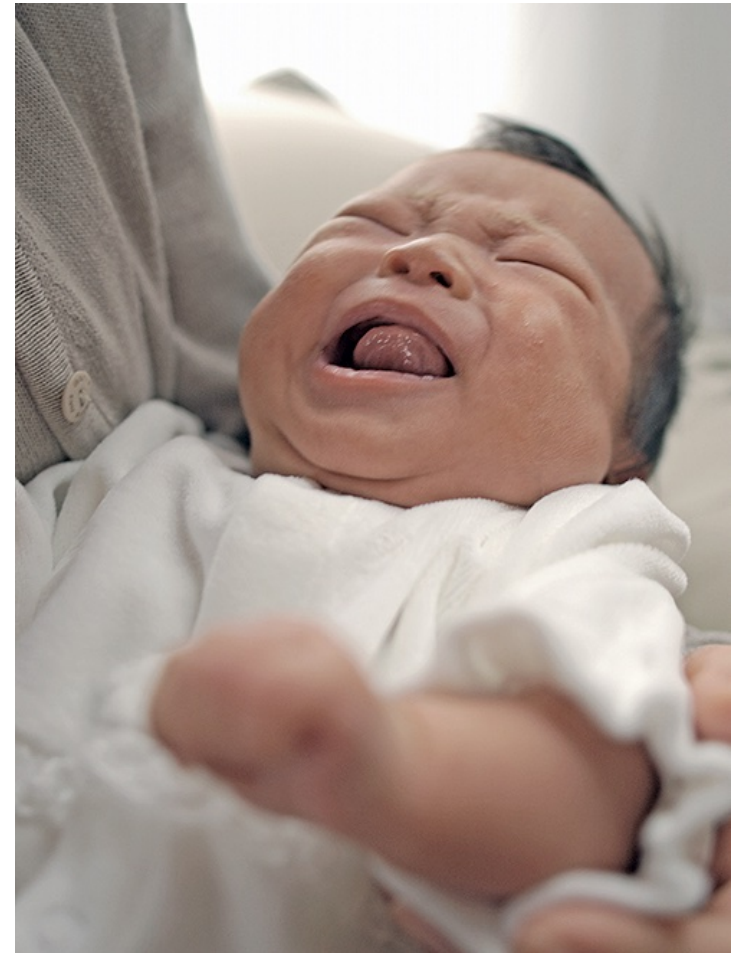


3-month-olds smile more at...  
real faces than at non-faces  
familiar adult (vs. unfamiliar adult)



# Expressing emotions: Fear

- Generalized distress is visible from birth
- ~7 months and beyond: fear is often displayed in response to...
  - Stranger anxiety (peak ~7-10 months)
  - Separation anxiety (peak ~15 months)
  - Nonsocial fears



# Expressing emotions: Fear

- Kinds of stimuli that elicit fear, across development

TABLE 5.3 Children's Fears

| Age         | Stimuli Causing Fear                                                                                                        |
|-------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 0–1 year    | Loss of support; loud noises; unexpected, looming objects; strangers; heights                                               |
| 1–2 years   | Separation from parent; injury; strangers; baths (down the drain with the water)                                            |
| 2–3 years   | Separation from parent; animals, especially large dogs; insects; darkness                                                   |
| 3–6 years   | Separation from parent; animals; darkness; strangers; bodily harm; imaginary beings such as monsters and ghosts; nightmares |
| 6–10 years  | Snakes; injury; darkness; being alone; burglars; new situations such as starting school                                     |
| 10–12 years | Negative evaluations by peers; school failure; thunderstorms; ridicule and embarrassment; injury; burglars; death           |
| Adolescence | Peer rejection; school failure; breaking up; family issues such as divorce; war and other disasters; the future             |

Sources: Gelfand & Drew, 2003; Goetz & Myers-Walls, 2006.

# The secondary (self-conscious) emotions

embarrassment, guilt, shame, pride, jealousy, empathy

- Related to our sense of self and our consciousness of others' reactions
- Emerge during 2nd year
- Embarrassment emerges around 15-24 months
- By ~3 years, pride is increasingly tied to performance





# Emotion regulation

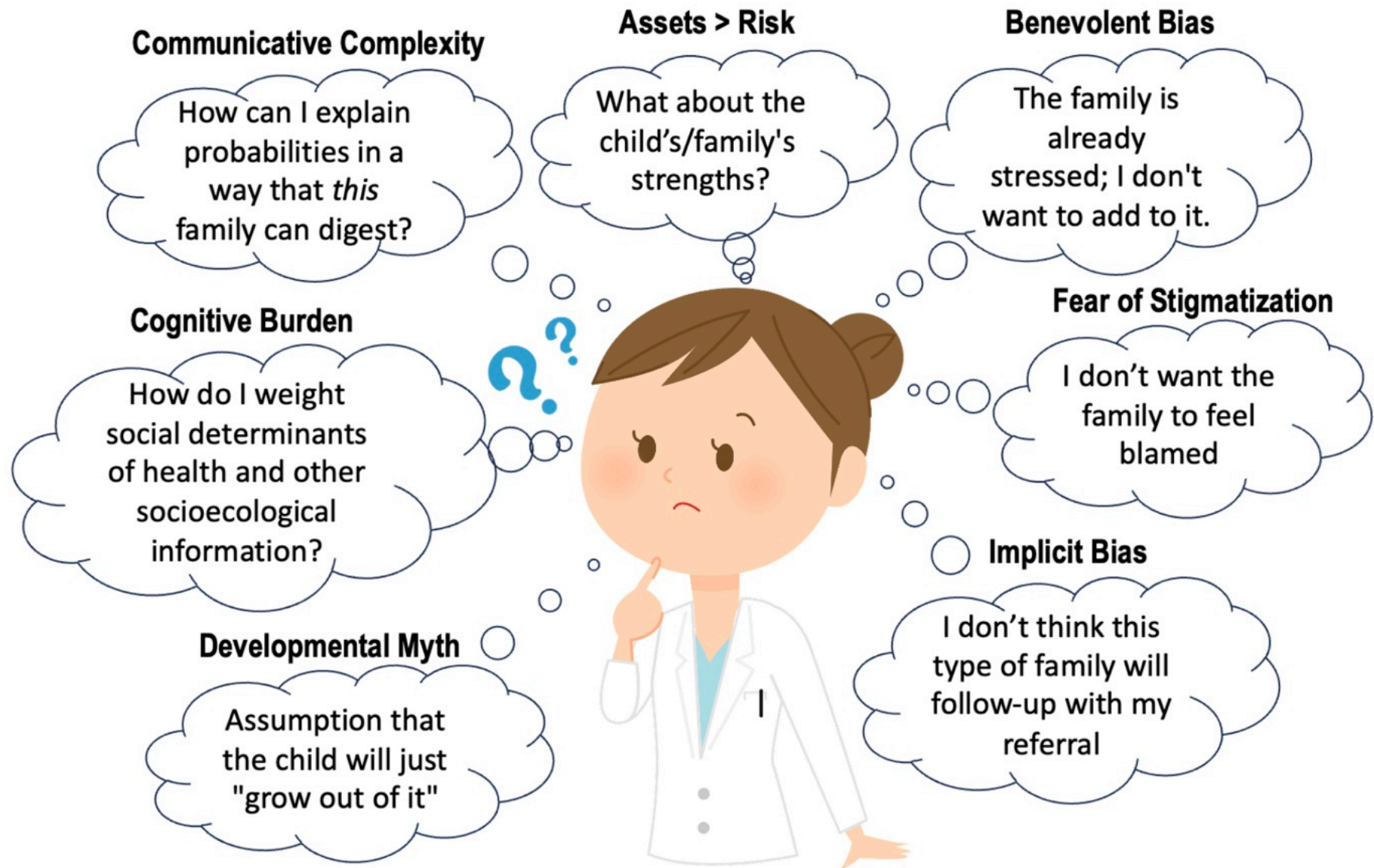
...the slowest-developing human behavior?

**The ability to effectively manage and respond to an emotional experience.**

Difficulty regulating negative emotions (especially irritability) is a central deficit that underlies over a dozen DSM disorders. This is the most robust developmental predictor of mental health problems.



# When should clinicians **worry vs. act** when there's a suspected mental health problem?



Understanding others' emotions



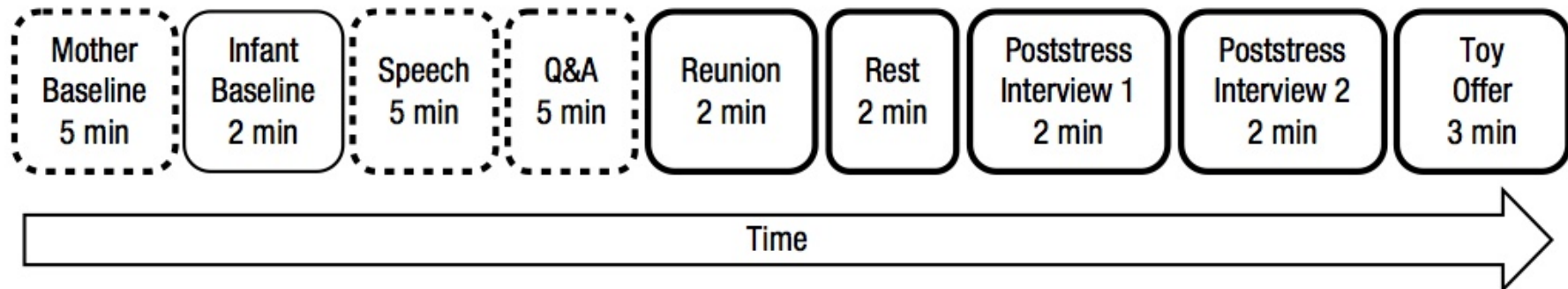
# Understanding others' emotions

- More convincing evidence: social referencing
  - Visual cliff
  - Emotion & unfamiliar objects
    - Findings at 12 months:
      - Happy ✓
      - Neutral ✓
      - Fearful ✗



# Emotion (stress) contagion

- Mothers + 12-month-old infants



**Fig. 1.** Overview of the procedure. Dashed outlines indicate that the mother was alone; for all other periods, the mother and infant were together. Bold outlines indicate the periods from which the mother's and infant's physiological data were taken for covariation analyses. Q&A = question-and-answer session.

# Understanding others' emotions

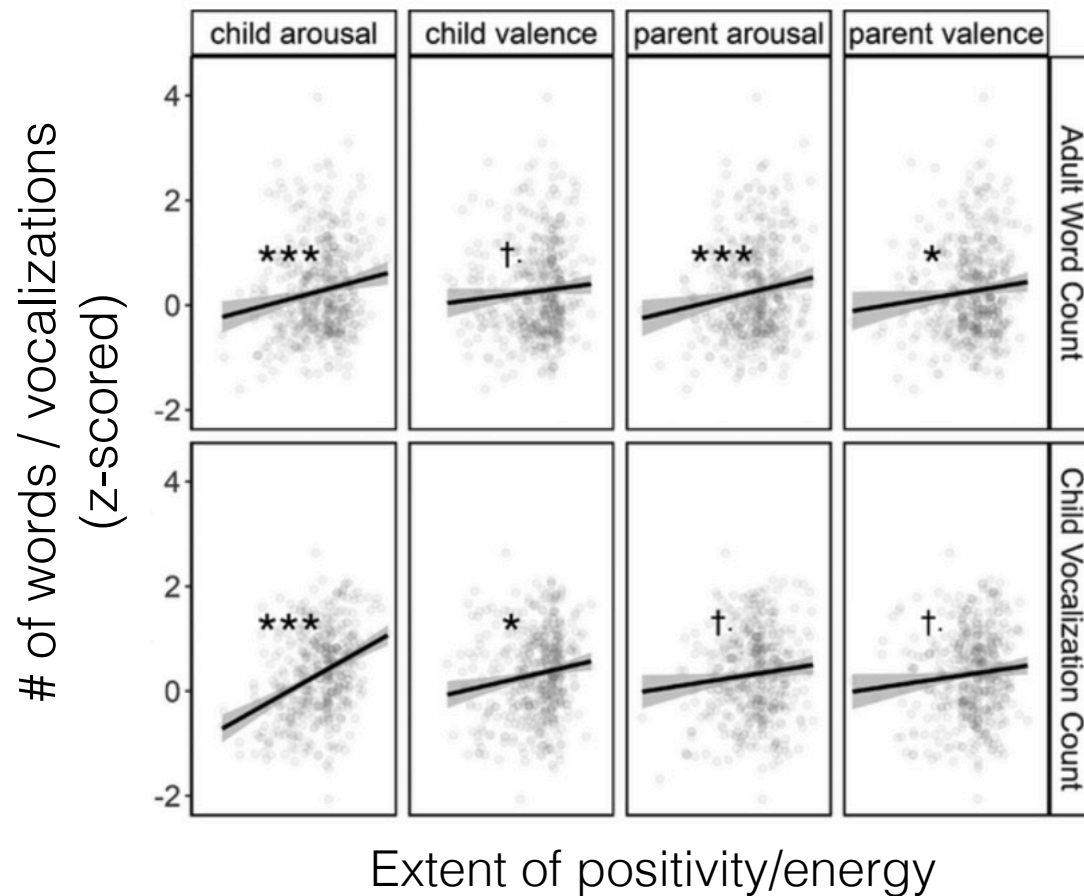




# Emotion & Language

# Emotion shapes language use and language learning

Adults and children talk more during interactions with positive emotions or higher energy



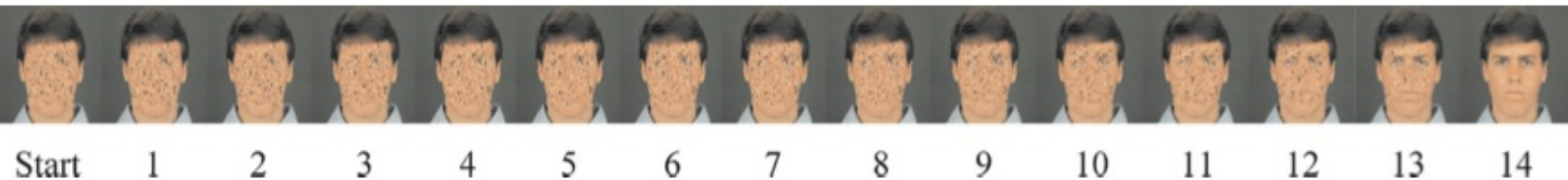
And children tend to learn words more easily from such interactions.

Individual differences

or, Breakdowns in the family environment

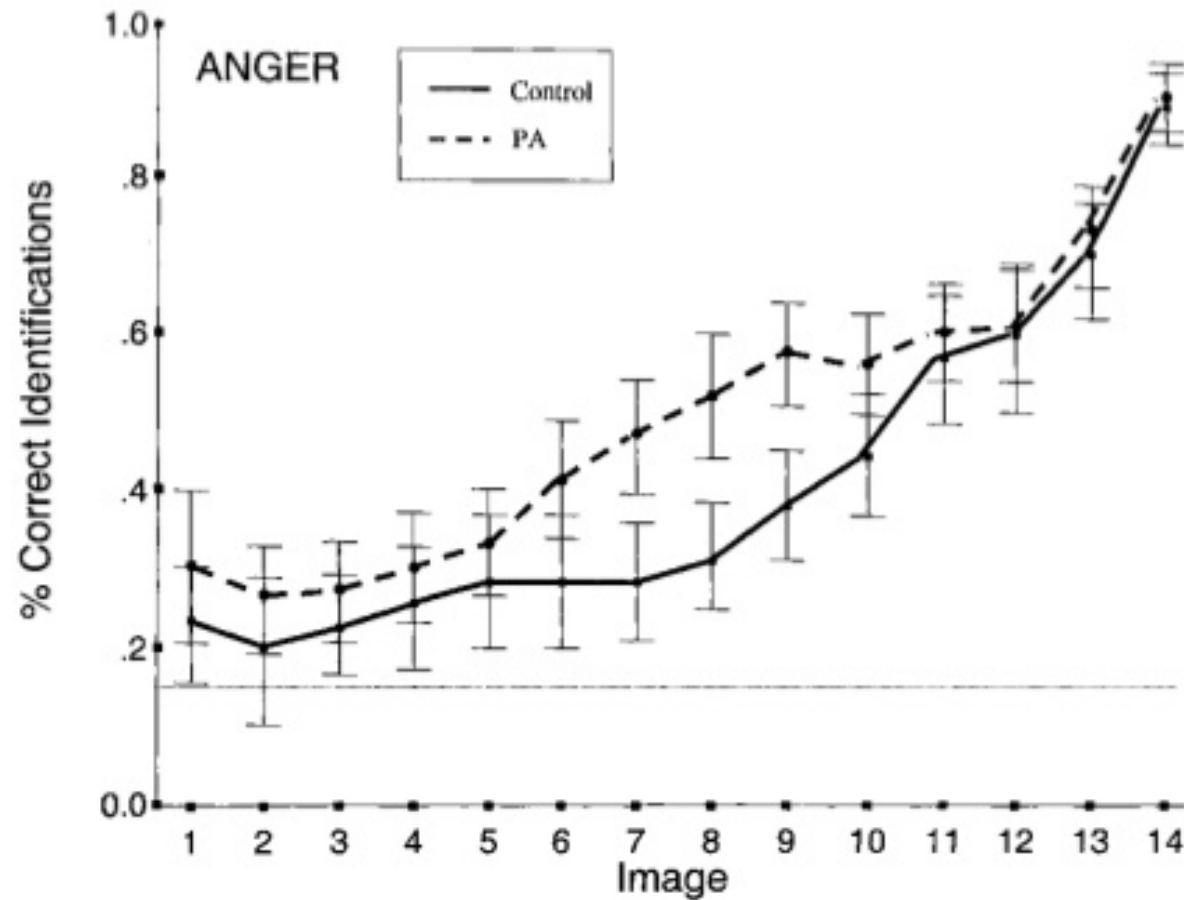
# Individual differences in experience: Emotional abuse

- **Question:** does extensive exposure to a particular emotion affect emotion perception?
- **Two groups of children:** (1) children living in emotionally abusive homes, (2) non-maltreated children





# Individual differences in experience: Emotional abuse



# Individual differences in experience: Neglect



Feel free to go read about the Bucharest Early Intervention Project. It's amazing.

<https://www.pbs.org/newshour/health/how-detention-causes-long-term-harm-to-children>

# Individual differences in experience: Neglect

- **Question:** how does neglect affect emotion recognition and understanding?
- **Two groups of children:** (1) children who had been institutionalized, (2) children living with their biological families
- **Two tasks:** emotion identification & emotion understanding
- **Findings:**
  - Emotion identification: previously institutionalized children worse than controls for all emotions
  - Emotion understanding: previously institutionalized children worse than controls for all emotions *except anger*
  - Time in institution
  - Order of identifying/understanding different emotions



# Cultural differences: Display rules





# Cultural differences: Display rules

- **Question:** are children sensitive to cultural values about 'display rules'?
- One example:
  - Study of 8- to 11-year-old children in two countries
  - **Nepal:** 'collectivist' society: respect authority, maintain social harmony, and promote group welfare
  - **U.S.:** 'individualistic' society: individual autonomy, self-expression, and pursuit of individual goals

# Cultural differences: Display rules

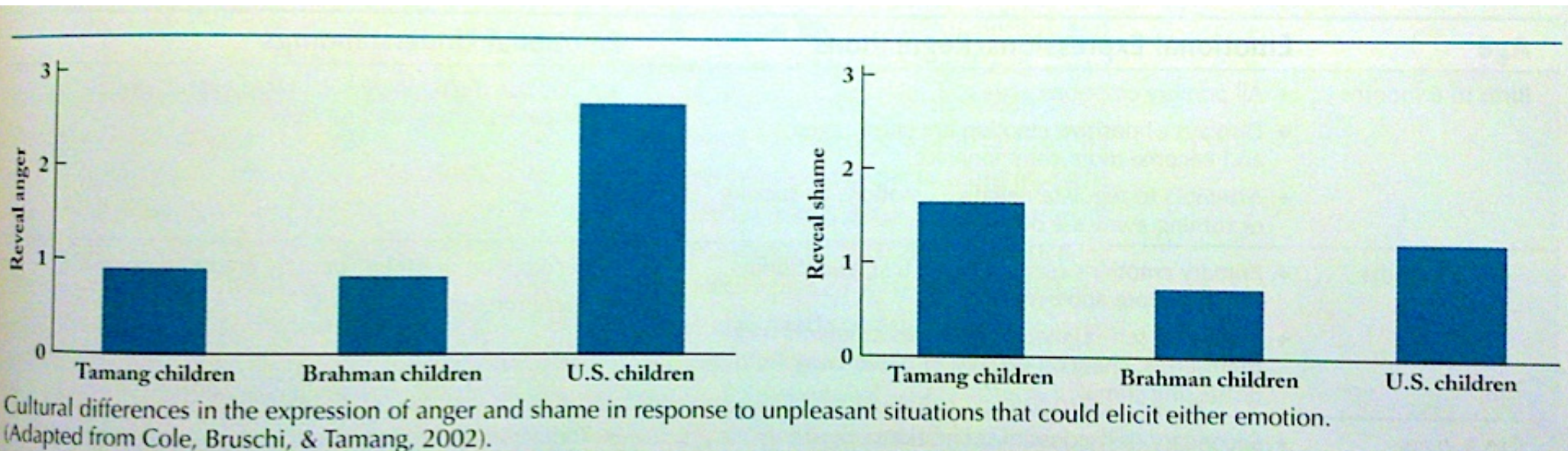
- Asked about kids' reactions to situations that could elicit anger or shame
- **Nepal (“Collectivist”)**
  - Shame is okay; it acknowledges wrongdoing & submission to authority
  - Anger is discouraged; signals self-assertions and threatens harmony
- **U.S. (“Individualistic”)**
  - Shame is viewed as harmful to one's self-esteem
  - Anger is tolerated when it is in the interest of self-assertion and individual rights (and non-hostile)

# Cultural differences: Display rules

- Kids heard scenarios like this:

*You're doing your homework. Your father is sitting next to you. You want to use the eraser and you see it by his hand. You take the eraser and your father slaps your hand and says, "Don't grab things – wait until I'm finished!"*

- Then asked how they would feel and what feelings they would openly express.





Why don't undergrads go to shows at McCarter?? Tickets are free to you and it's amazing stuff! Emotion displays are everywhere.





# Emotion & attachment:

## Viral wedding proposals

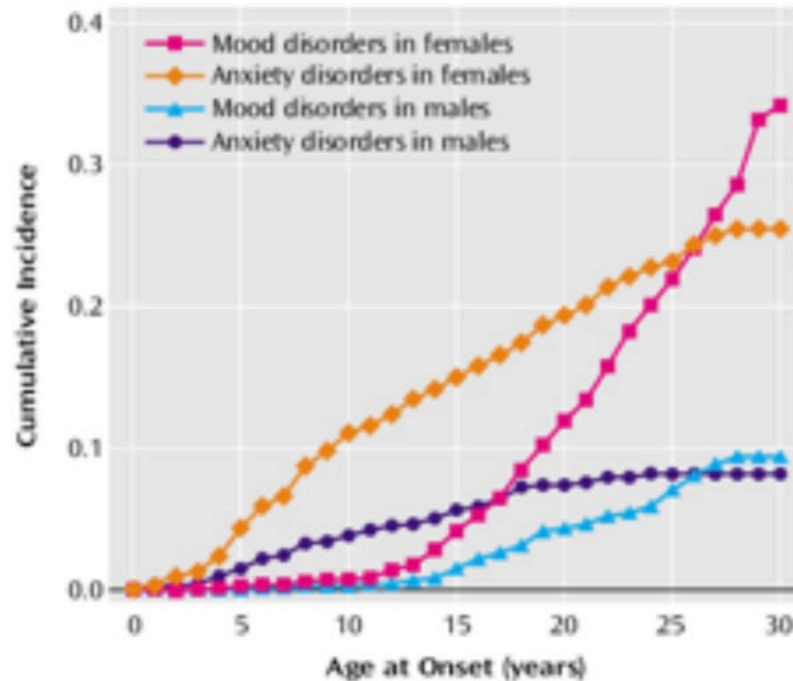


# Emotion & attachment:

## Military reunions



# Implications for mental health



(Roza et al., 2003)

|                           | Projected lifetime risk, <sup>a</sup> % (s.e.) |
|---------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Anxiety disorders         | 31.5 (1.1)                                     |
| Mood disorders            | 28.0 (0.8)                                     |
| Impulse control disorders | 25.4 (1.1)                                     |
| Substance use disorders   | 16.3 (0.6)                                     |
| Any disorder              | 50.8 (1.2)                                     |

- Approximately 50% of Americans meet criteria for a mental disorder in their lifetime (Kessler et al., 2005).
- Anxiety disorders tend to develop earlier than mood disorders

So, remember to be kind to yourselves  
and to each other



SPOTLIGHT

FOCUS  
FEATURES

SERIES

Everybody loves...

# BABIES



"Extraordinary!"



"Irresistible."



"Joyous and Buoyant."

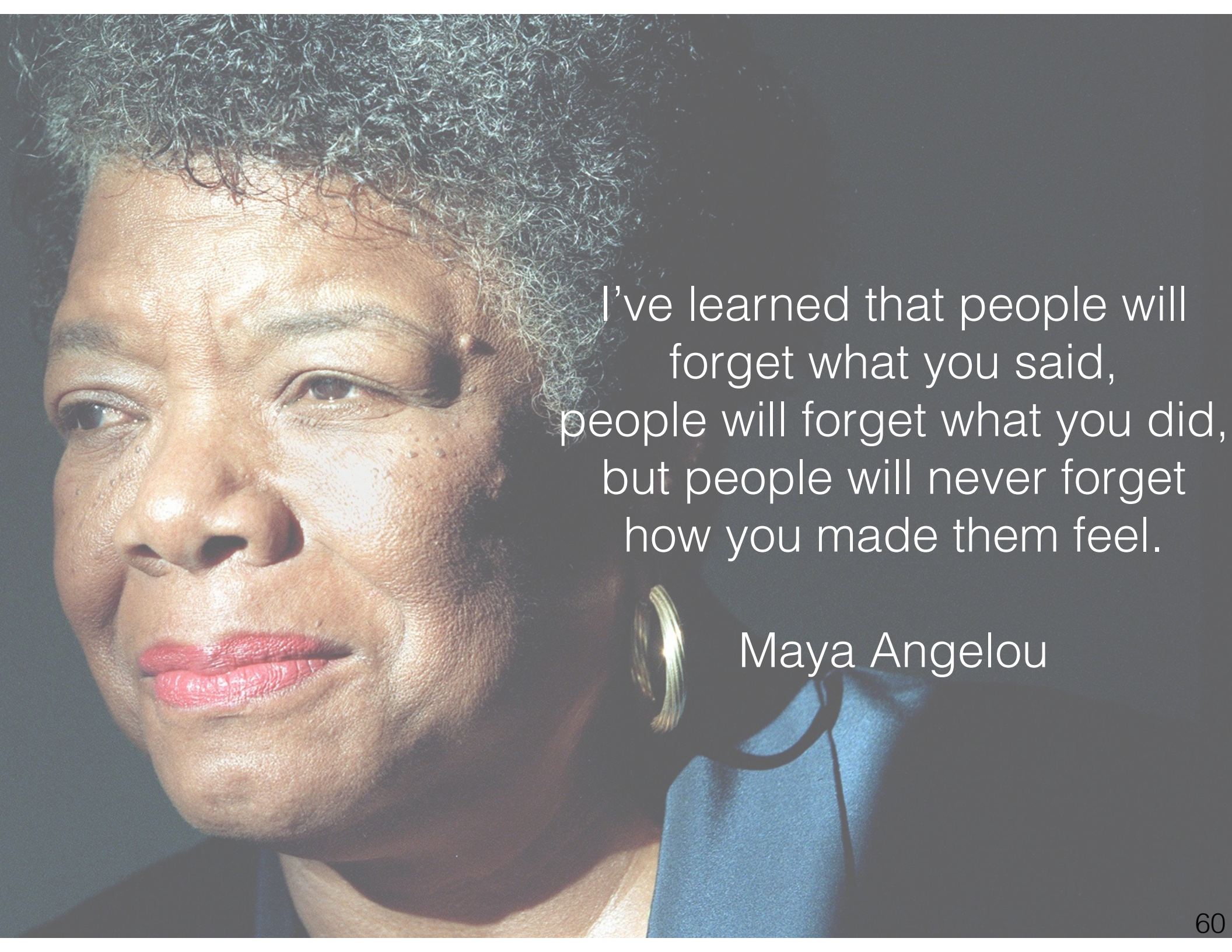


"Wonderful!"



# FOUR NEW BABIES



A close-up portrait of Maya Angelou, an African American woman with short, curly grey hair. She is looking slightly to the left with a gentle expression. She is wearing a blue garment and a large, gold-colored hoop earring. The background is dark and out of focus.

I've learned that people will  
forget what you said,  
people will forget what you did,  
but people will never forget  
how you made them feel.

Maya Angelou